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What We Really Know About the Russian 'Plague' Case

关于俄罗斯“疫病”病例，我们真正了解的情况

逐段中英对照 · 英文原文浅灰底 / 中文译文浅蓝底

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元信息 / Metadata

标题 (Title，英文原标题): What We Really Know About the Russian 'Plague' Case

标题中文译名 (Title in Chinese，由翻译引擎生成): 关于俄罗斯“瘟疫”病例，我们真正了解的情况

副标题 (Deck，英文原文): Even though many questions remain unanswered, the death probably isn’t cause for panic.

副标题中文译文 (Deck in Chinese，由翻译引擎生成): 尽管许多问题仍未得到解答，但这次死亡事件可能并不值得恐慌。

作者 (Author，原文署名作者): Katherine J. Wu

栏目 (Section，文章所属栏目及媒体): Health — The Atlantic

发布时间 (Published，原文发布时间): 2026 年 10 月（archive.today 首次快照 2026-10-06 17:40:19 GMT）

来源 URL (Source，原文链接): https://www.theatlantic.com/health/2026/10/russia-plague-pneumonia-panic/688897/

抓取日期 (Retrieved，抓取时间，UTC): 2026-10-12 (UTC)

抓取方式 (Method，抓取手段说明): 直接 curl/wget（浏览器 UA、Googlebot UA）均被 Cloudflare 拦截返回 HTTP 403 “Please hold a moment…”；r.jina.ai 同样 403；archive.today 各镜像网页直连被限流 HTTP 429。最终改用 keenable MCP 的 `fetch_page_content` 工具（POST https://api.keenable.ai/mcp，JSON-RPC tools/call）抓取原始 URL 成功，返回完整正文 Markdown。

交叉校验 (Cross-check，与快照版本比对结果): 同一文章另经 keenable 抓取 archive.md 快照（http://archive.md/20261010143911/https://www.theatlantic.com/health/2026/10/russia-plague-pneumonia-panic/688897/）比对，段落数一致（12 段），首尾段落与全部正文内容一致（快照版个别处为 “plague”、实时版为 “the plague” 等轻微差异，且超链接被重写为 archive.li 代理链接）。确认为完整正文。

完整性 (Completeness，正文完整程度): 完整正文（全文，非摘要）。图片、脚注、评论区与页脚导航未包含。

翻译引擎 (Translation engine，所用模型与接口): Index-Translate-35B-A3B（接口地址 https://index-translate.bilibili.com/v1，OpenAI Chat Completions 兼容，temperature=0，enable_thinking=false，逐段调用，每段一次请求）

段落总数 (Paragraph count): 共 12 段，逐段一一对照，无遗漏。

正文逐段中英双语对照 / Paragraph-by-Paragraph Bilingual Text

第 1 段 / Paragraph 1

EN • 英文原文

In a world on edge still from the last pandemic, rumors of a deadly disease that could have escaped from a lab can cause some understandable distress—however speculative they might be. Late last week, reports emerged that a woman who died in a Siberian hospital may have contracted the plague, or even that she had seeded a plague outbreak. The case almost immediately set off rounds of hurried speculation within Russia and abroad; officials have shared few details, inspiring elaborate theories about what killed the woman, who worked in a plague-research facility. The fervor around the case escalated on Sunday, when *Axios* reported that the State Department was monitoring a “suspected plague outbreak” in Russia.

ZH • 中文译文

在上次大流行病过后，世界仍处于高度紧张之中，此时任何关于致命疾病可能从实验室泄露的传闻，都可能引发人们可以理解的不安——即便这些传闻纯属猜测。上周末，有报道称，一名在西伯利亚一家医院去世的女子可能感染了鼠疫，甚至有传言称她引发了鼠疫暴发。此案几乎立即在俄罗斯国内外引发了新一轮仓促的猜测；由于官方披露的细节寥寥无几，各种关于这名在鼠疫研究机构工作的女性的死因的复杂理论层出不穷。围绕此案的紧张情绪在周日进一步升级，当时Axios 报道称，美国国务院正在监测俄罗斯境内一起“疑似鼠疫暴发”事件。

第 2 段 / Paragraph 2

EN • 英文原文

So far, the evidence that the death was caused by plague or something worse is thin, in part because Russian authorities—who have a poor reputation for transparency about biosecurity—have shared few clarifications. But scientists have a good understanding of how the plague works. And if the lab worker did contract the plague, that is no cause for international panic.

ZH • 中文译文

到目前为止，能够证明此次死亡是由鼠疫或更严重疾病导致的证据十分薄弱，部分原因在于俄罗斯当局——其在生物安全方面的透明度声名狼藉——几乎没有提供任何明确的解释。不过，科学家们对鼠疫的传播机制已有充分的了解。即便这名实验室工作人员确实感染了鼠疫，也无需引发国际社会的恐慌。

第 3 段 / Paragraph 3

EN • 英文原文

Here’s what is actually known. Sometime in the past week, a woman who worked at the Irkutsk Anti-Plague Research Institute of Siberia and the Far East, not far from the Mongolian border, died of “pneumonia of an unknown cause,” Rospotrebnadzor, Russia’s agency for consumer protection and public health, said Sunday. Government officials have not confirmed her identity, but Russian media have reported that the woman was Daria Shipilova, a 27- or 28-year-old technician at the lab. A local official said that the hospital where she was treated has been placed under quarantine; local media, meanwhile, reported that *several* hospitals were under quarantine. And Igor Kobzev, the governor of the Irkutsk region, said in a statement on Friday that other people—local media later reported the number as 200—may have been in contact with a resident who contracted an “especially dangerous infection,” and were placed under medical observation. He did not identify the resident as Shipilova or say that the person had died. The public-health agency told state media that “no micro-organisms linked to her professional activity were identified in the patient’s samples” and that no contacts have experienced “health changes related to infectious pathology.” Meanwhile, an aluminum factory in the same town as the laboratory imposed a mask mandate for its more than 2,000 employees, *The Wall Street Journal* reported.

ZH • 中文译文

以下是目前已知的情况。俄罗斯消费者权益与公共卫生监督局周日表示，在过去一周内的某个时间点，一名在西伯利亚及远东地区伊尔库茨克市（靠近蒙古边境）的反鼠疫研究所工作的女性死于“原因不明的肺炎”。政府官员尚未确认其身份，但俄罗斯媒体报道称，该女子为27或28岁的实验室技术员达里娅·希皮洛娃。一位当地官员表示，她曾接受治疗的医院已被隔离；与此同时，当地媒体报道称有数家医院处于隔离状态。此外，伊尔库茨克州州长伊戈尔·科布泽夫周五在一份声明中表示，其他人——当地媒体后来报道称人数为200人——可能与一名感染了“特别危险的传染病”的居民有过接触，因此被置于医学观察之下。他并未指明该居民就是希皮洛娃，也未说明此人已经死亡。公共卫生机构向官方媒体透露，“在患者的样本中未发现与其职业活动相关的微生物”，且所有接触者均未出现“与传染性疾病相关的健康状况变化”。与此同时，据《华尔街日报》报道，与该实验室位于同一城镇的一家铝厂已要求其2000多名员工佩戴口罩。

第 4 段 / Paragraph 4

EN • 英文原文

Plague might sound medieval, but it’s endemic among animals in many parts of the world today. Although Russia hasn’t reported any plague cases to the WHO since at least 2018, Mongolia has. An average of seven cases are recorded in the United States every year, typically from a flea bite or handling infected animals. More than 80 percent of U.S. cases are the bubonic form of the disease, which presents with swollen, pus-filled lymph nodes. Two other main forms of plague, all caused by the same bacterium, are also occasionally reported around the world: septicemic, which infects the blood, and pneumonic, which infects the lungs. Because the lab worker died of pneumonia, speculation that she’d died from plague centered on this last form.

ZH • 中文译文

“瘟疫”一词听起来或许带有中世纪色彩，但如今在世界许多地区，它仍是动物中的一种地方性疾病。尽管俄罗斯至少自2018年以来从未向世界卫生组织报告过任何瘟疫病例，但蒙古则有报告。美国平均每年记录七例，通常由跳蚤叮咬或接触受感染动物所致。美国超过80%的病例属于腺鼠疫，其症状是淋巴结肿大并充满脓液。此外，全球偶尔也会报告另外两种同样由该细菌引起的瘟疫类型：败血症型（感染血液）和肺鼠疫型（感染肺部）。由于这名实验室工作人员死于肺炎，外界推测她可能死于瘟疫时，焦点便集中在最后一种类型上。

第 5 段 / Paragraph 5

EN • 英文原文

Pneumonic plague is the sole form of the disease that can transmit between humans, but that doesn’t mean it’s particularly likely to spread. David Wagner, the executive director of Northern Arizona University’s Pathogen and Microbiome Institute, told me that the respiratory droplets that can spread pneumonic plague—not to be confused with the tinier aerosols that can spread diseases such as flu and COVID—are only released during a cough or sneeze and only travel about three to six feet. “You have to be in very close proximity to someone with pneumonic plague to contract it from them,” he said.

ZH • 中文译文

腺鼠疫是唯一一种可以在人际间传播的鼠疫形式，但这并不意味着它特别容易扩散。北亚利桑那大学病原体与微生物组研究所的执行主任戴维·瓦格纳告诉我，能够传播腺鼠疫的呼吸道飞沫——注意，这不同于能够传播流感和新冠肺炎等疾病的更微小的气溶胶——只有在咳嗽或打喷嚏时才会释放出来，并且传播距离仅约三到六英尺。他说：“你必须与腺鼠疫患者处于非常近距离接触，才有可能被传染。”

第 6 段 / Paragraph 6

EN · 英文原文

Because transmission between humans is relatively difficult, the Russian government's response to the mystery death from pneumonia—placing 200 people under medical observation—is "really incongruent with what you would expect for plague," Amesh Adalja, an infectious-disease physician at Johns Hopkins University, told me. Daniel Jernigan, the former director of the CDC's National Center for Emerging and Zoonotic Infectious Diseases, told me that response was "above and beyond" what is typically required for plague cases. Perhaps, he said, the Russian authorities acted out of an abundance of caution; per Reuters, a local official recently said that most of the hospital workers who had been placed under quarantine have already been released.

ZH · 中文译文

约翰斯·霍普金斯大学的传染病医生阿梅什·阿达尔贾告诉我，由于人际传播相对困难，俄罗斯政府对这起神秘肺炎死亡病例的应对措施——将200人置于医学观察之下——"与人们对鼠疫的通常预期确实不符"。美国疾病控制与预防中心（CDC）前国家新兴和动物源性传染病中心主任丹尼尔·杰尼根也表示，这一响应"远超"处理鼠疫病例通常所需的程度。他说，俄罗斯当局或许是出于过度谨慎而采取了行动；据路透社报道，一位当地官员最近表示，此前被隔离的大多数医院工作人员现已解除隔离。

第 7 段 / Paragraph 7

EN · 英文原文

Even if Shipilova did die of plague, fears of a larger outbreak are probably moot by now. Plague has an incubation period of only one to seven days, so anyone Shipilova might have exposed would have come down with symptoms by now, Jernigan said. Russian authorities have said that no one under medical observation has tested positive for the plague. Generally speaking, the chances of a large outbreak of plague are slim. "Once you have an accurate diagnosis, it's readily treated with multiple types of antibiotics, which is why we don't have massive plague outbreaks and pandemics anymore," Wagner said.

ZH • 中文译文

即使希皮洛娃确实死于鼠疫，现在担心疫情大规模爆发的可能性恐怕也已经不大了。杰尼根表示，鼠疫的潜伏期仅为一至七天，因此希皮洛娃可能接触过的人如今早已出现症状。俄罗斯当局称，目前接受医学观察的人员中，尚未有人检测出鼠疫呈阳性。总体而言，鼠疫大规模爆发的可能性微乎其微。瓦格纳说：“一旦确诊，多种抗生素都能有效治疗，这就是我们如今不再出现大规模鼠疫暴发和全球大流行的原因。”

第 8 段 / Paragraph 8

EN • 英文原文

Very quickly, though, some scientists, security experts, and media outlets began speculating that whatever killed Shipilova was not traditional pneumonic plague, but a dangerous pathogen that had been somehow altered in the lab. The fear is that the pathogen could be resistant to antibiotics or other treatments, making it harder to prevent an outbreak. No evidence so far suggests that’s true or that the Irkutsk lab was modifying plague bacteria to make it more dangerous. Still, the host of unanswered questions surrounding this case has paved the way for conjectures about links to biological weapons and for conspiracy thinking about government collusion and vaccine companies set to profit off a plague pandemic.

ZH • 中文译文

然而，很快一些科学家、安全专家和媒体就开始推测，导致希皮洛娃死亡的并非传统的肺鼠疫，而是一种在实验室中以某种方式被改造过的危险病原体。人们担心这种病原体可能对抗生素或其他治疗方法具有耐药性，从而增加疫情暴发的防控难度。目前尚无证据表明情况属实，也没有证据显示伊尔库茨克实验室曾试图改造鼠疫杆菌以增强其危险性。尽管如此，围绕此案的一连串悬而未决的问题，为各种猜测提供了温床，包括将其与生物武器关联起来的猜想，以及关于政府勾结、疫苗公司准备从鼠疫大流行中牟利的阴谋论。

第 9 段 / Paragraph 9

EN • 英文原文

Some Russian media outlets reported—and international outlets repeated—that the woman contracted the plague after she broke a test tube containing a sample of the disease. (If that was the case, Adalja said, the lab should have followed the standard procedure of prescribing antibiotics immediately after exposure, which has not been reported.) And in the past, the Russian government has worked on bioterrorist agents and hidden the true cause of disease outbreaks. For example, Soviet officials attributed a 1979 anthrax outbreak that killed at least 64 people to contaminated meat. More than a decade later, President Boris Yeltsin admitted that the anthrax had come from a military biological-weapons facility.

ZH • 中文译文

一些俄罗斯媒体报道称——国际媒体也跟进报道——这名女子在打碎一个装有该疾病样本的试管后感染了鼠疫。（如果情况属实，阿达尔贾表示，实验室本应在接触后立即按照标准程序开具抗生素，但目前并未有相关报道。）此外，俄罗斯政府过去曾研究过生物恐怖主义制剂，并隐瞒过疾病暴发的真正原因。例如，苏联官员曾将1979年导致至少64人死亡的炭疽病暴发归咎于受污染的肉类。十多年后，鲍里斯·叶利钦总统承认，炭疽病源自一处军事生物武器设施。

第 10 段 / Paragraph 10

EN • 英文原文

The war in Ukraine has increased speculation about planned biological threats. In 2022, the Russian military began refurbishing a Soviet-era laboratory to handle deadly pathogens such as Ebola viruses, *The Washington Post* reported. “There’s just a standard lack of transparency from the Russian government that adds to the vacuum of information,” Adalja said.

ZH • 中文译文

乌克兰战争加剧了外界对于有预谋的生物威胁的猜测。据《华盛顿邮报》报道，2022年，俄罗斯军方开始翻新一间苏联时期的实验室，用于处理埃博拉病毒等致命病原体。阿达尔贾表示：“俄罗斯政府一贯缺乏透明度，这加剧了信息真空。”

第 11 段 / Paragraph 11

EN • 英文原文

The U.S. government, for its part, has given inconsistent signals about whether it believes that the incident has wider implications. Along with the State Department, the CDC and the Administration for Strategic Preparedness and Response are reportedly working to learn more about the death. But Secretary of State Marco Rubio downplayed the possibility of danger to reporters yesterday, saying, “I don’t think it’s cause for alarm, but it is cause for focus and a cause to just keep an eye on it.” Today, he called on Russia to be more transparent and share more information. President Trump has offered his sympathies to Russia and said that the U.S. will offer help, though he didn’t specify what form that would take. (The White House did not respond to a request for comment.)

ZH • 中文译文

就美国政府而言，其关于是否认为该事件具有更广泛影响的表态一直前后不一。据报道，国务院、美国疾病控制与预防中心以及战略准备与应对管理局正协同合作，以进一步了解该死亡事件的详情。但国务卿马尔科·卢比奥昨日向记者淡化了存在危险的可能性，他表示：“我不认为这值得恐慌，但确实值得我们关注，需要持续留意。”今天，他则呼吁俄罗斯方面提高透明度并分享更多信息。特朗普总统已向俄罗斯表示慰问，并称美国将提供帮助，尽管他并未具体说明将以何种形式提供帮助。（白宫尚未回应置评请求。）

第 12 段 / Paragraph 12

EN • 英文原文

The strong public reaction to the death in Siberia can likely be attributed to some surface-level similarities to the early days of the coronavirus pandemic—a mysterious respiratory disease, rumors of a lab leak, an initial response being handled by a secretive government. Still, the experts I spoke with were adamant that pneumonic plague would not be another COVID-19. Plague may not be totally relegated to the history books, but a major outbreak is low on the list of real threats.

ZH • 中文译文

西伯利亚这起死亡事件引发强烈公众反响，很可能归因于它与新冠疫情初期的一些表面相似之处——一种神秘的呼吸系统疾病、有关实验室泄漏的传闻，以及由一个神秘政府主导的初期应对。尽管如此，我采访的专家们坚称，肺鼠疫不会成为另一个“新冠”。鼠疫或许尚未彻底成为历史，但大规模暴发并非迫在眉睫的主要威胁。